# When a Legal Escalation Is Ready to Close

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Companion files: github.com/ingridkuo/legal-workflow-lab/tree/main/08_practitioner_notes

**At a glance**

**Built:** A definition of when a legal escalation is ready to close, and a Python and SQLite prototype that applies it to 12 synthetic scenarios.

**Found:** All 12 scenarios matched their expected behavior. The prototype blocked transitions that lacked an accepted handoff, a counsel decision, an execution receipt, or an owner for continuing preservation.

**Why it matters:** A sent email is not completion. A case is ready to close when an authorized decision has led to verified action and anything that continues has an accepted owner.

A tracker can say "closed" as soon as a coordinator sends an email. The email may ask somebody else to act, leaving the substantive task unfinished. When the record contains no accepted handoff or execution receipt, the next person cannot tell whether the instruction reached its owner, whether anyone acted on it, or whether a further decision remains open.

That is a useful problem for legal program design. Before automating reminders or summaries, a team needs an agreed definition of completion. My proposed definition is narrow: a case is ready to close when an authorized decision has led to verified action and any continuing obligation has an accepted owner. The definition comes from practice: as the only lawyer at a public-works contractor, I built its contract intake, review, and approval process, with escalation by contract value and tracking to signature.

This note develops that definition through a reference workflow and a companion demonstration using synthetic records. It focuses on coordination among Legal, Product, Safety, Security, and User Operations. The aim is to make ownership and completion inspectable, including when a request arrives with incomplete information.

## Authority before automation

An intake record often combines different kinds of judgment. A coordinator may recognize that a request needs attention without having authority to decide its legal merits. A security specialist may confirm a technical event without deciding what communication or retention action follows. Clear roles keep those judgments attached to the people responsible for them.

NIST's AI Risk Management Framework places documented responsibilities, training, and leadership accountability within governance. Its Generative AI Profile provides additional guidance for applying governance to generative AI systems.[1][2] I use those frameworks to support an operating choice: establish human decision authority before allowing automation to advance a case.

| Role | Responsibility in the reference design | Decision boundary |
|---|---|---|
| Program coordinator | Collect facts, route questions, confirm accepted ownership, track blockers, and check completion evidence | Does not supply missing legal approval |
| Counsel or designated legal decision maker | Decide the legal question, approve the applicable action, and determine preservation instructions | Does not presume operational execution from a recommendation |
| Security, Safety, or User Operations owner | Investigate or execute actions within the owner's authority and provide a receipt | Does not treat an AI recommendation as authorization |
| Records custodian | Carry out and maintain authorized preservation instructions | Does not infer release from case closure |

An AI-generated summary can help prepare a decision packet. It should not populate the approval field as though counsel had signed off. OWASP's discussion of excessive agency supports constraining the actions and permissions available to AI-assisted processes.[3] In this design, a recommendation and an authorization remain separate records.

## A record another person can reconstruct

The tracker should hold enough information to explain progress without becoming an unnecessary second repository of sensitive material. A compact record needs a case identifier, intake key, intake time, request type, redacted summary, source reference, and source version. It also needs named owners, the next action, relevant dates, and the evidence supporting the current status.

Reported facts, assumptions, and unresolved questions deserve separate fields. "A user reported exposure" and "Security confirmed exposure" describe different evidence states. Combining them into a confident narrative can change the apparent basis for a decision.

Dates also need a clear basis. Distinguish internal targets from deadlines supplied by an authoritative source. The prototype uses illustrative case review and completion targets for overdue reporting. These are not acknowledgment targets, legal deadlines, or employer service commitments.

Source references should point to permissioned records, with a version identifying the basis for each decision. A classification label alone does not enforce access. Deployment requires authenticated identities, authorization checks, and appropriate storage controls.

## Progression with evidence gates

These proposed stages separate receipt, decision, execution, and confirmation.

| Stage change | Evidence required to advance |
|---|---|
| Received to needs information | A specific missing item and an owner for obtaining it |
| Received to triaged | A request type, source reference, priority basis, and visible information gaps |

| Stage change | Evidence required to advance |
|---|---|
| Triaged to assigned | Named receiving owners and an accepted handoff |
| Assigned to ready for execution | The applicable decision or approval and a defined authorized action |
| Ready for execution to pending confirmation | Receipts for the required actions |
| Pending confirmation to closed | Completion checked, required communications recorded, and continuing obligations assigned |

Incomplete information should not suppress urgent routing. A reported urgent signal can enter the established specialist path while the coordinator continues gathering facts. The routing event should identify the basis for urgency and preserve uncertainty about unverified details.

After assignment, a blocker should remain attached to the case and its owner. Moving a record into a generic waiting column can conceal responsibility. A useful blocker states what is missing, who will obtain it, and what the next follow-up should accomplish.

## A fictional case through the workflow

Consider a fictional report from a product team: an exported support summary may contain information from another customer, and a scheduled cleanup could affect the relevant records. The report is incomplete. It identifies a sample file but does not show who received it or what the cleanup will delete.

The coordinator records those uncertainties, links the sample in its restricted source location, and routes the reported issue under the example team's existing escalation procedure. Security accepts responsibility for investigating distribution. User Operations accepts responsibility for any approved customer-facing action. Counsel receives a defined question about the proposed response and the records that may need preservation.

The coordinator does not turn the report into a confirmed incident or determine the scope of a preservation obligation. The pending preservation question is recorded separately. A deployment handling destructive actions should prevent execution while required preservation review remains unresolved.

Suppose counsel then records an instruction covering the relevant source records. A records custodian accepts continuing responsibility. Security supplies its findings, and counsel authorizes a defined response based on those findings. The execution owner completes the authorized action and links its receipt. Where a communication is required, the record identifies the approved content and evidence that it was sent.

At that point, the coordinator checks the source version, decision reference, accepted owners, receipts, and unresolved tasks. A sent email requesting action would not satisfy that check. An execution receipt linked to the authorized task could.

The operational case can close while the preservation track remains active, provided the applicable decision permits that separation and the continuing custodian has accepted responsibility. Closing the case must not automatically release the preservation instruction. A later release requires its own authorized decision and execution record.

This distinction avoids an unhelpful choice between keeping every case open indefinitely and losing track of obligations that outlast the immediate response.

## Measure the queue as well as completed work

A fuller operating report should show intake completeness, unaccepted handoffs, blocker age, decision wait time, and missing receipts, and it should identify cases reopened after apparent completion. These proposed measures point to different interventions: better intake questions, clearer ownership, additional decision capacity, or more reliable execution checks.

Latency measures need pending items alongside completed ones. A median acknowledgment time calculated only from acknowledged requests can look reassuring while older requests remain unanswered. A reporting snapshot should retain those pending cases and show their age.

Closure-gate results also need clear denominators. Repeated attempts to close one case are multiple attempts, not multiple cases. A report should distinguish blocked attempts from affected cases and explain which missing condition triggered each rejection.

## What the demonstration can establish

The companion prototype makes a limited claim: specified workflow rules can be executed and inspected against fixed synthetic scenarios. Its records and event history allow a reviewer to examine why a proposed transition succeeded or failed.

Twelve workflow scenarios matched their expected behavior. The checks covered missing owners, unaccepted handoffs, missing counsel decisions, missing execution receipts, pending preservation review, ongoing preservation ownership, duplicate intake, source changes, and overdue reporting. The implementation rejected a counsel decision before an operational owner had accepted the handoff. A source-version change invalidated the earlier decision and execution receipt.

| Result from the synthetic run | Observed count |
|---|---|
| Scenarios matching expected behavior | 12 of 12 |
| Cases in the register | 12 |
| Final states | 2 closed, 7 blocked, 3 assigned |
| Overdue nonclosed cases at the fixed snapshot | 1 |
| Closed cases with an accepted active preservation follow-up | 1 |
| Recorded audit events | 62 |

The runner uses Python and SQLite, an explicit external-to-canonical field mapping, and configurable routing. Its SQL reports show state, owner workload, overdue cases, and preservation commitments. These are computed from stored case and event records. The fixed simulation clock and authored dates produce a repeatable snapshot; they do not measure staff effort.

The prototype implements a subset of the reference design. It checks required references, source-version alignment, handoff acceptance, and closure prerequisites, and pending preservation review blocks

closure. It does not implement intake information gathering, urgent routing, multi-team handoffs, communication checks, a pre-execution preservation gate, or the latency and quality measures proposed above. Nor does it fetch external receipts, verify that an action occurred, run the full fictional case, or decide whether a preservation instruction is legally appropriate. A referenced receipt is a required record in this exercise; substantive verification remains a deployment responsibility.

These observations support statements about the implemented controls and the exercised inputs. They do not measure real team responsiveness, legal accuracy, user-safety outcomes, or production security, and simulated roles do not show that a production system authenticates the person claiming a role.

## Release requires an owner for adoption

A small pilot should begin with one bounded request category and a named process owner. Before release, that owner should confirm the decision roles, required fields, escalation paths, and examples of acceptable completion evidence. Receiving teams need to accept the handoff definition, including what they are expected to acknowledge and return.

Training can then use the fictional case to show how an incomplete report moves forward, where counsel's decision is required, and why closure can fail. A short guide should explain how to correct missing information and how to report a rule that prevents legitimate work.

The release decision should consider rejected transitions and user effort alongside throughput. If staff repeatedly bypass a field, the process owner should investigate whether its purpose is unclear, the evidence is unavailable, or the gate is poorly placed. Changes should receive a version, a responsible approver, and a regression check against the established scenarios.

A reliable closure record gives the next person a concrete account of the decision and its execution. It also makes unfinished work visible. That is the standard an automation should help a team maintain.

## Method and references

This independent practitioner exercise uses fictional scenarios and synthetic records. The reference workflow and prototype do not represent an employer's policy or confidential work. The companion results identify the checks actually executed. The prototype and its results are at github.com/ingridkuo/legal-workflow-lab/tree/main/08_practitioner_notes, separate from the repository's 06_knowledge_operations folder.

[1] NIST. Artificial Intelligence Risk Management Framework. NIST AI 100-1, January 2023. GOVERN 2.1 through 2.3. https://doi.org/10.6028/NIST.AI.100-1

[2] NIST. Artificial Intelligence Risk Management Framework Generative Artificial Intelligence Profile. NIST AI 600-1, July 2024. GV-2.1-002. https://doi.org/10.6028/NIST.AI.600-1

[3] OWASP. LLM06 Excessive Agency. Secure Agent Playbook official repository. Accessed November 10, 2026. https://github.com/OWASP/secure-agent-playbook/blob/main/data/llm-top10/LLM06.md